Dealshape: brief for an outside review

Lina Mockeliunaite · 20 October 2026 · a working prototype I built with AI as the build partner. All companies, people, products and deals in it are fictional.

> **What I'm asking you for (three things):**
>
> 1. **Stress-test the concept.** Is the problem real, is this the right product for it, and who would actually use it or pay for it?
> 2. **Propose alternative demo scenarios**, judged against the criteria in section 9.
> 3. **Suggest enhancements to the screens** (section 6), ranked by impact. Each must respect the design rules in section 4.
>
> Please be direct. Lead with the weakest point. Don't repeat the weaknesses I've already listed in section 8 unless you think I've understated one.

1. The product in 30 seconds

When a B2B software deal is signed, Delivery inherits the contract. But the customer remembers the proposal, the RFP answers and the sales calls. The gaps between the two surface at kickoff, as escalations.

Dealshape reads a deal's paper trail (calls, RFP response, proposal, internal pricing note, customer emails, draft SOW, draft contract, signed contract) and shows the shape of the deal:

- what we're delivering;
- which commitments need attention, and why;
- what people have agreed about them;
- which documents were checked.

It flags promises the company never authorised, promises that never made it into the contract, and promises the contract states differently. It is a **visibility tool, not a workflow tool**: there are no tasks, assignees, approvals or risk scores.

2. Who it's for, and when it's used

Who	Role
Delivery, Customer Success and Support leads	Inherit the deal and read the handover record
Sales or pre-sales deal owner	Adds documents and the handoff note during contract negotiation
COO or CEO	Looks at the locked record later: "what happened in this deal"

A Delivery lead described three moments of use:

1. while the SOW or contract is still open: "Am I comfortable taking this over?";
2. the formal handoff notes from Sales to Delivery;
3. handover complete, after which the record is locked.

3. How it works, and the trust model

1. **Read.** The documents are grouped by deal stage. **The stage comes from the documents** (a signed contract means Signed). Nobody sets it by hand.
2. **Detect (model).** One model call reads the documents with the product catalogue. It proposes each gap with exact quotes and citations.
3. **Verify (code).** Every quote and citation is checked mechanically. Findings that fail a check are never shown. "What we found" shows only what code verified; the model's own sentence carries an "AI-written summary" label.
4. **Recheck (code).** Add an updated document and the check runs again. A gap closes only when the new paperwork shows it no longer holds, and the screen names the document that closed it. **The model never closes anything.**
5. **Notes are a person's word, not proof.** A note either keeps a commitment open with context, or marks it "Addressed by note". That looks different from "Closed by documents", stays in the record, and reopens if the documents change.
6. **Handover.** Two notes (Sales and Delivery) and a signed contract are required. Completing the handover locks a read-only record that says honestly what is still open.

4. Design rules: suggestions must keep these

1. **Visibility, not workflow.** No tasks, assignees, approvals, deadlines, risk scores or AI-suggested business impact. Two reviewers, a COO and a Delivery lead, asked for this explicitly.
2. **The stage and the findings come from the documents,** never from a person's say-so.
3. **Status colours have one meaning each:** amber means Needs attention; solid green means Closed by documents (proof); outlined grey means Addressed by note (a person's word). Indigo is the brand and accent colour, never a status.
4. **AI-written text is labelled.** Verified facts and model text never look the same.
5. **"Mark as seen"** records who has looked at a commitment. It never closes or approves anything.
6. **The 10-second test:** a first-time viewer can say what we're delivering, what needs attention and why, what has been agreed, and which documents were checked.
7. **Nothing invented.** Every word and number on screen comes from the stored documents or the deal owner.

5. The demo scenario today: Alder Bank

The deal: Elva, a fictional AML and fraud platform vendor, is selling scam protection for a fictional Australian bank's outbound instant payments. Launch is 1 February 2027.

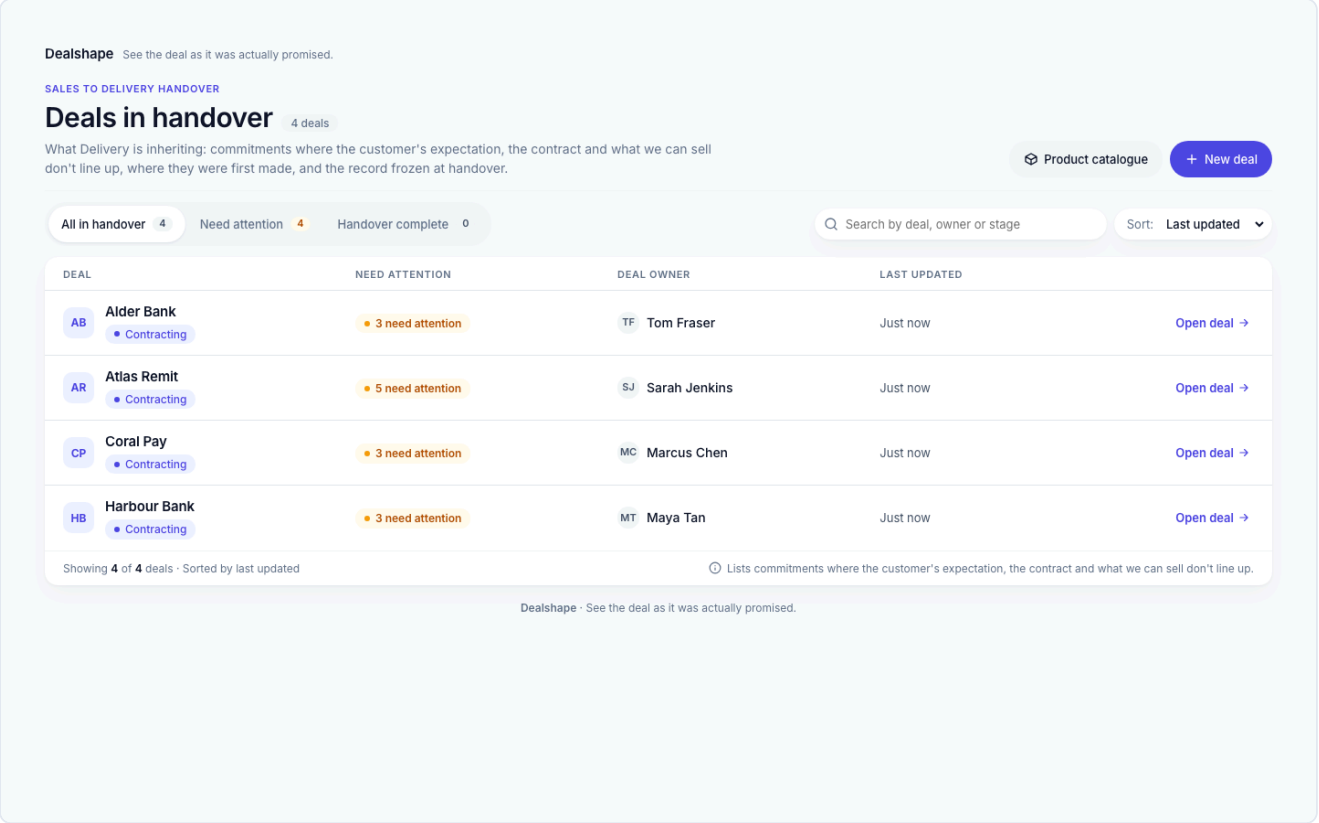
Commitment	What the customer was told	What the paperwork says
Coaching-scam detection live at launch	RFP response, 29 Sep	No matching wording in the contract or SOW; it needs a named approval, and none is recorded
Hosting on Microsoft Azure	RFP response, 29 Sep	The contract says AWS, Sydney region; Azure isn't offered
750,000 payments a day by end of year one	Proposal, 2 Oct	No matching wording; no approval found

The demo, about 4 minutes:

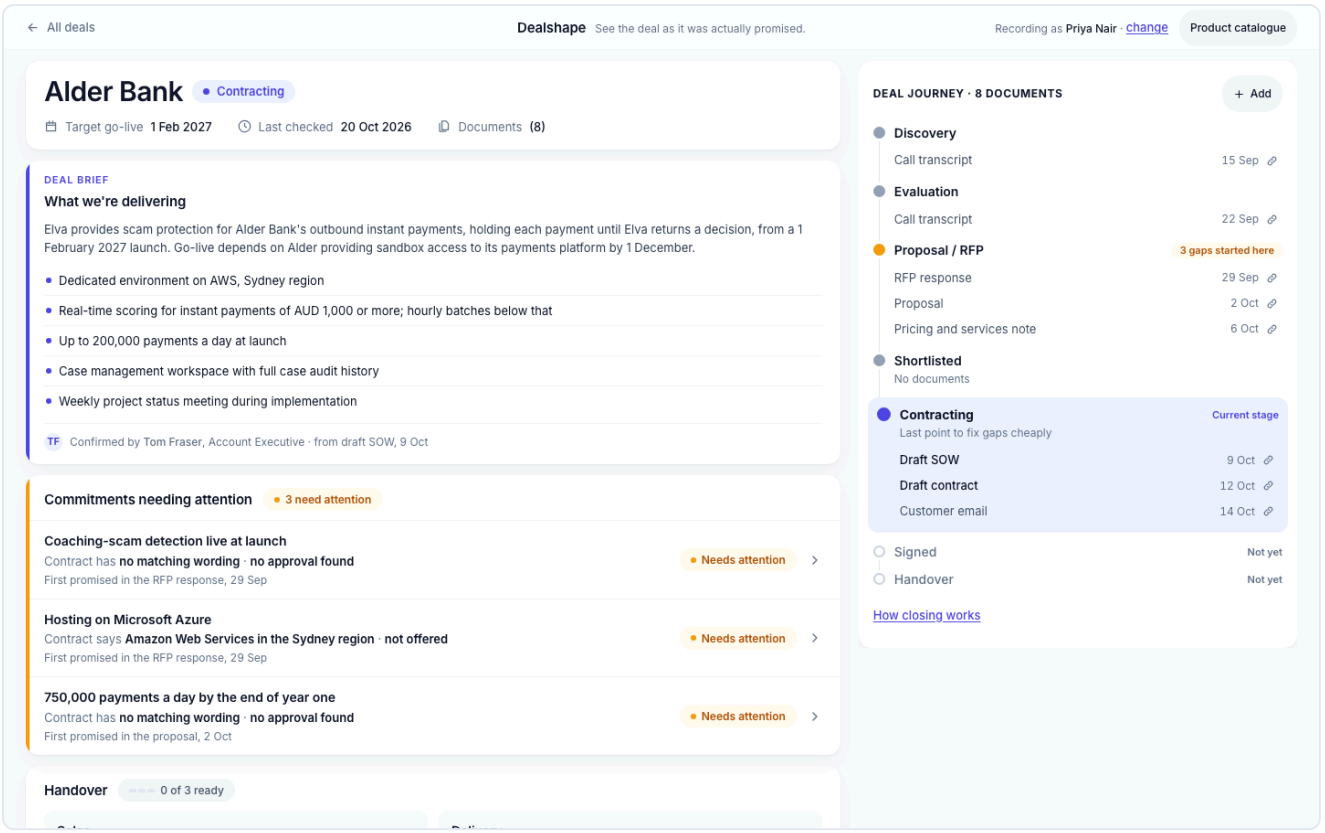
1. open the deal and read it in 10 seconds;
2. open the coaching commitment;
3. add a named exception: the approval gap closes, the contract gap stays open;
4. add an updated SOW: Closed by documents;
5. add a note on Azure: Addressed by note;
6. upload the signed contract: the stage moves to Signed;
7. write both handover notes and complete the handover;
8. show the locked record.

6. Screens

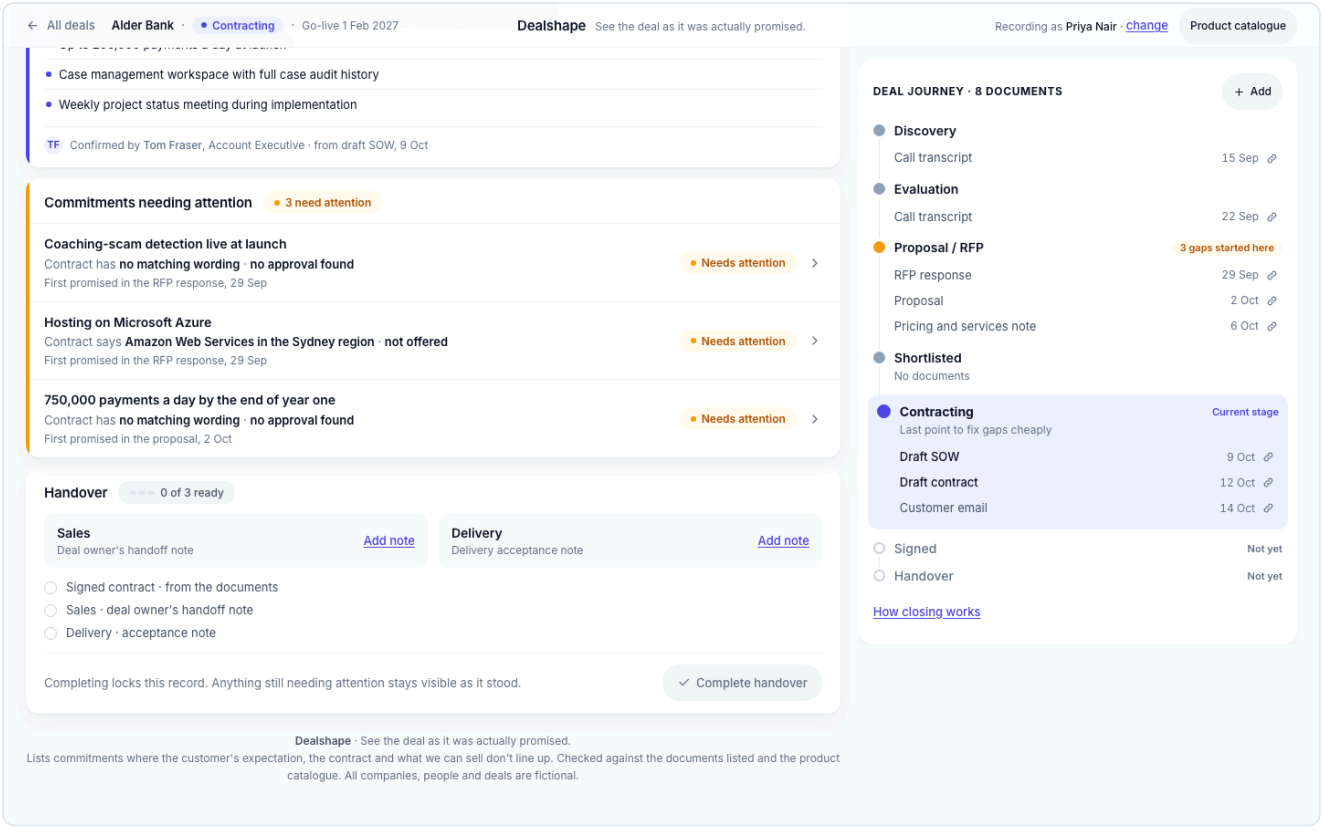
All screenshots are from the working app, at 1440 × 900, light mode, on the fictional demo data.



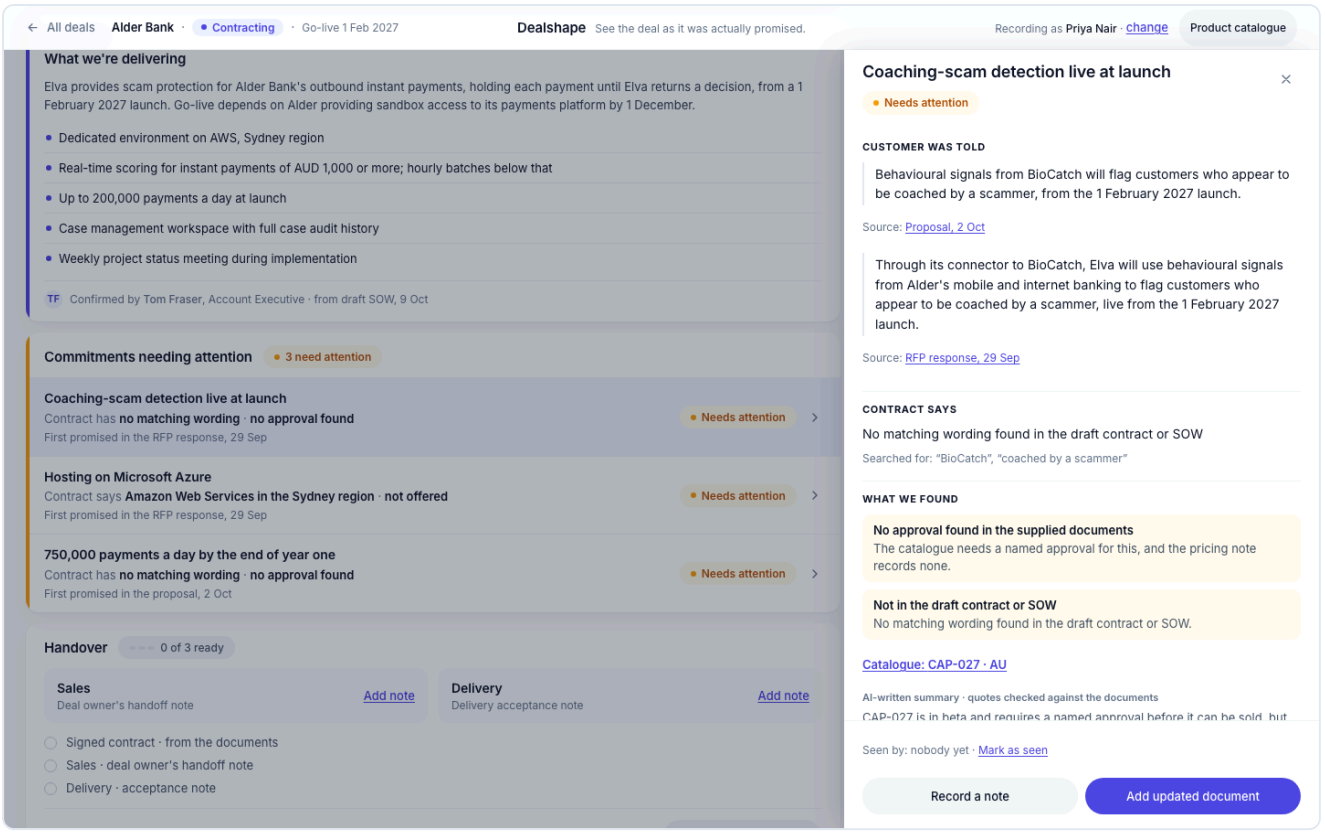
1 · Deals in handover (home). Only deals in Contracting or later are listed. The count shows how many commitments need attention.



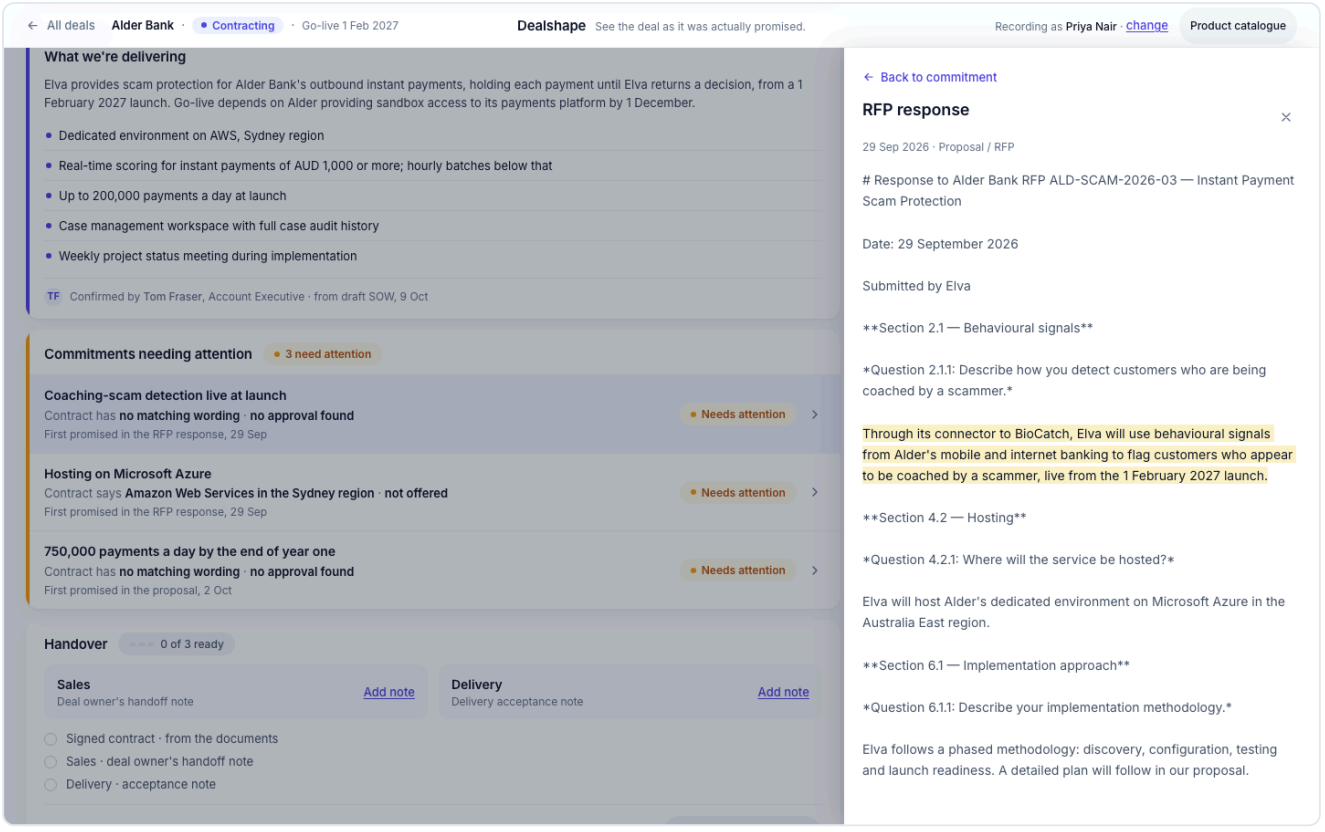
2 · Deal page, top. The header, the deal brief (indigo rule) and the commitments (amber rule). Each row's mismatch line is built only from verified finding labels. The sidebar shows the deal's journey by stage, with its documents and where the gaps started. This view is the 10-second test.



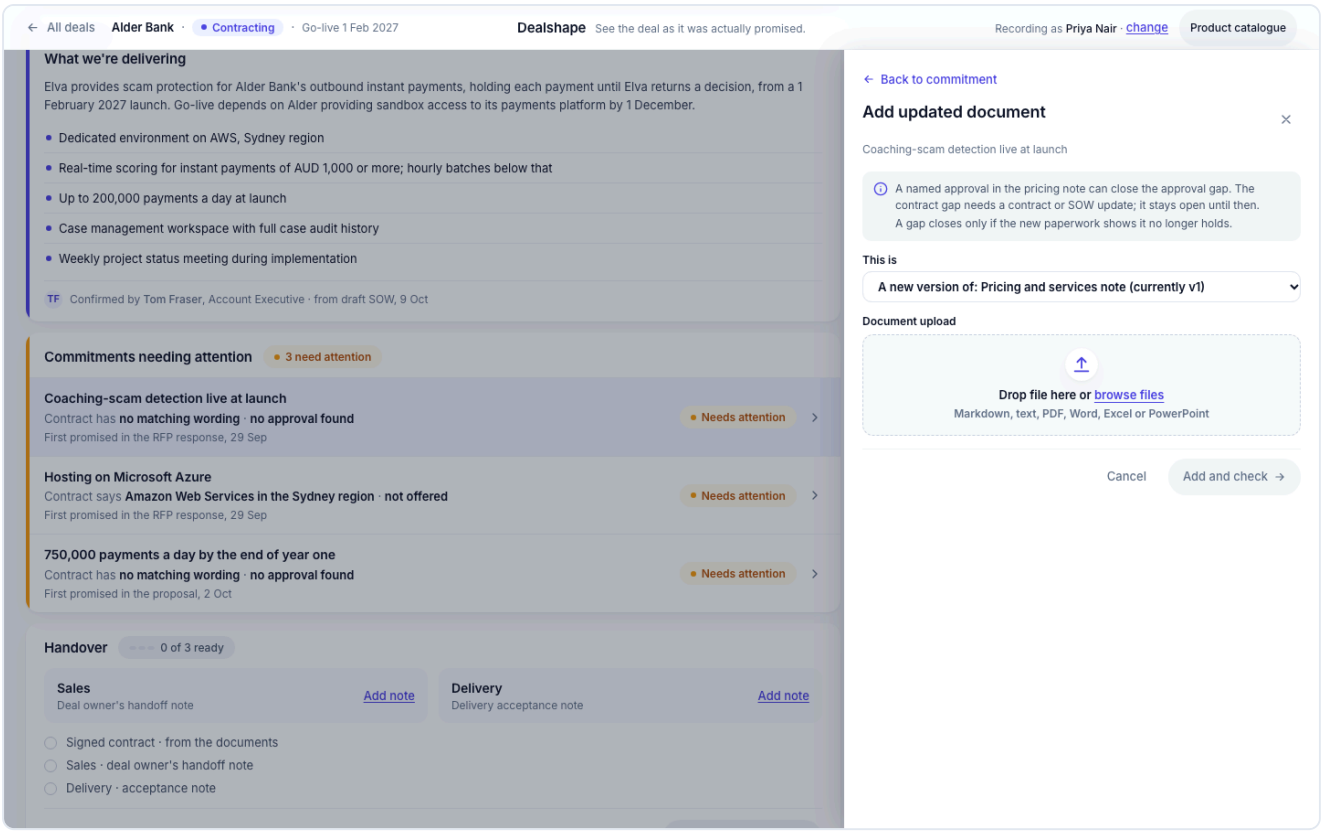
3 · Deal page, bottom: Handover. Two notes and a signed contract are required, shown as a checklist with a neutral "N of 3 ready" chip. The compact deal line appears in the top bar after scrolling.



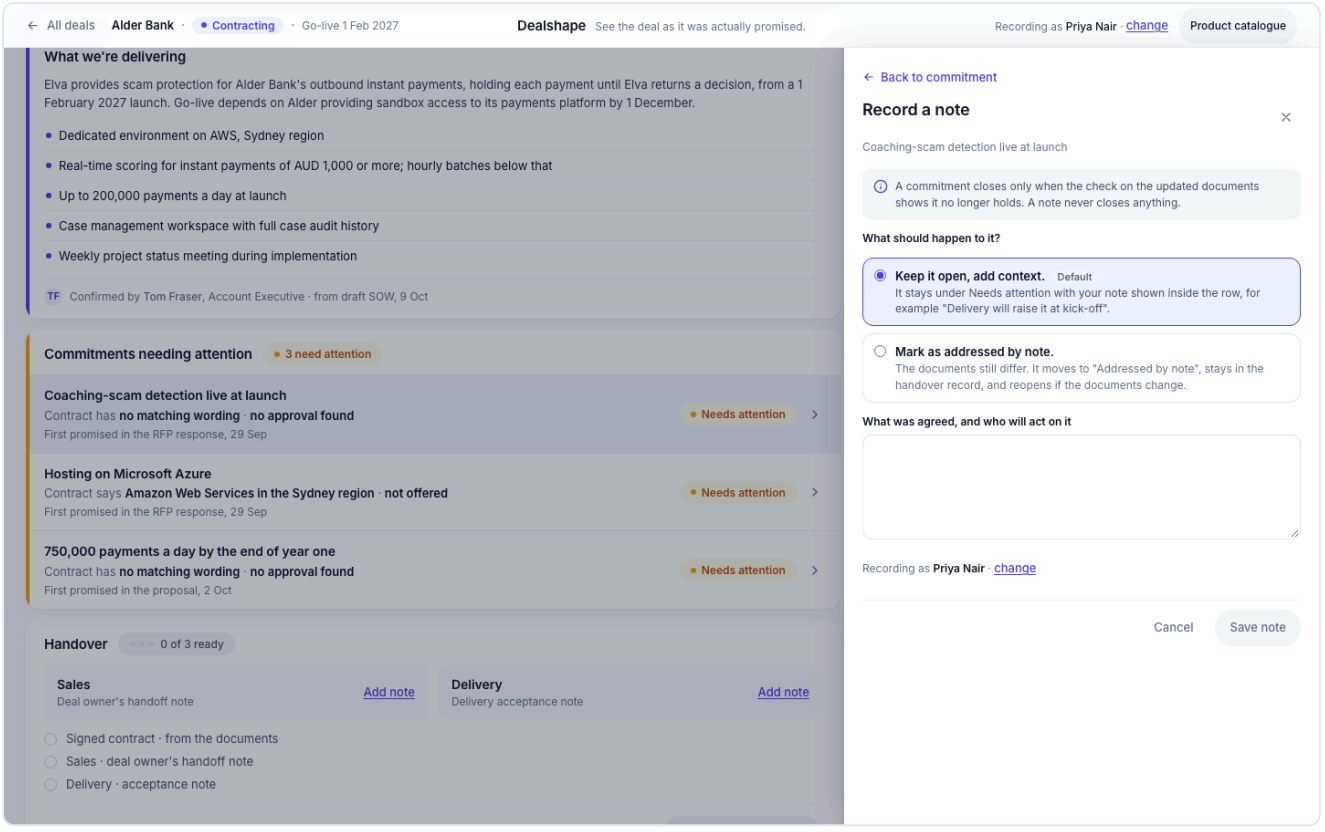
4 · A commitment, open in the drawer. The customer's checked quotes with their sources; the contract side ("No matching wording found", with the phrases searched for); the verified findings; then the AI-written summary under its own label. "Mark as seen" is a quiet link.



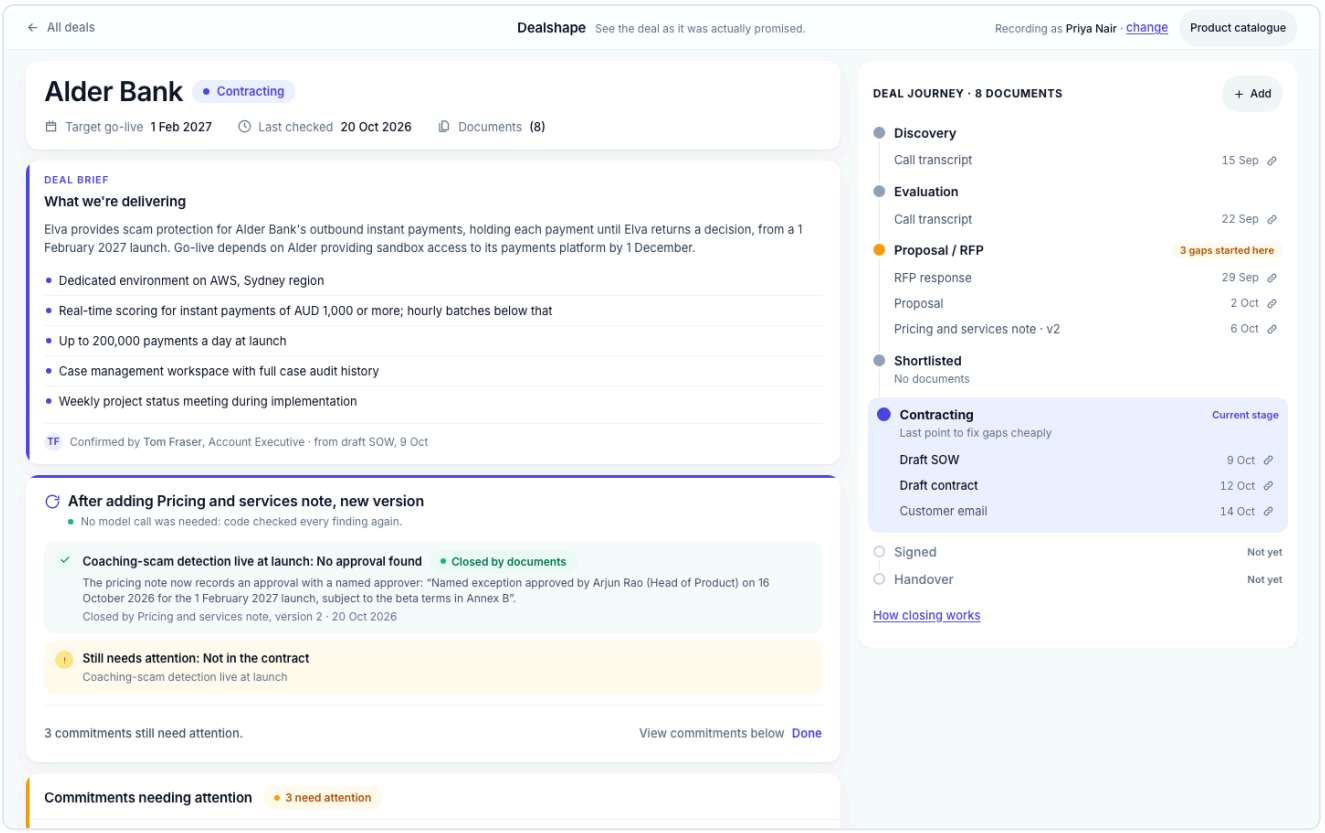
5 · A source document, opened from a quote. The quoted sentence is highlighted. The document is read-only.



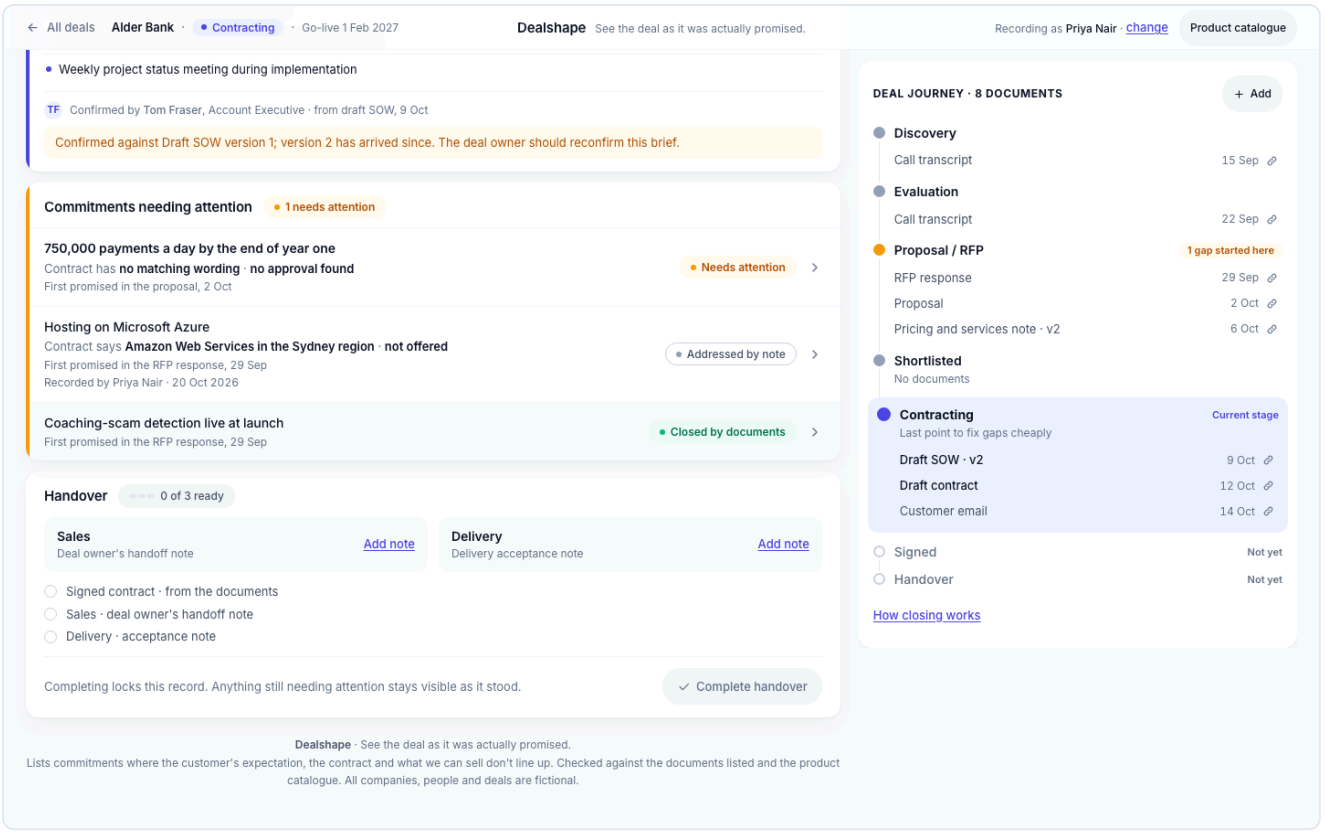
6 · Add updated document. The hint is specific to the gap. The document type is pre-selected as a new version of the right document. One call checks before it writes, so a failed check stores nothing.



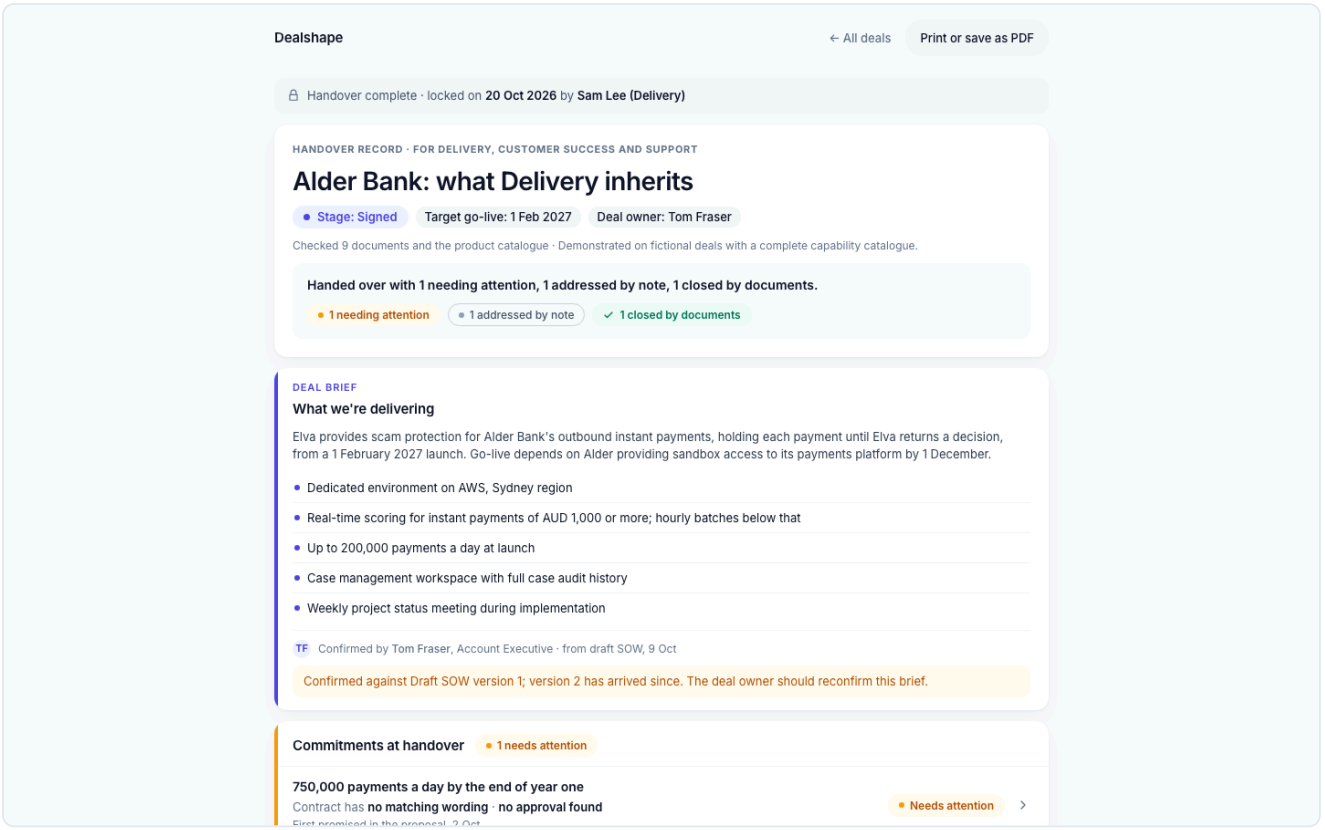
7 · Record a note. "Keep it open, add context" is the default. "Mark as addressed by note" is a deliberate choice, and it reopens if the documents change.



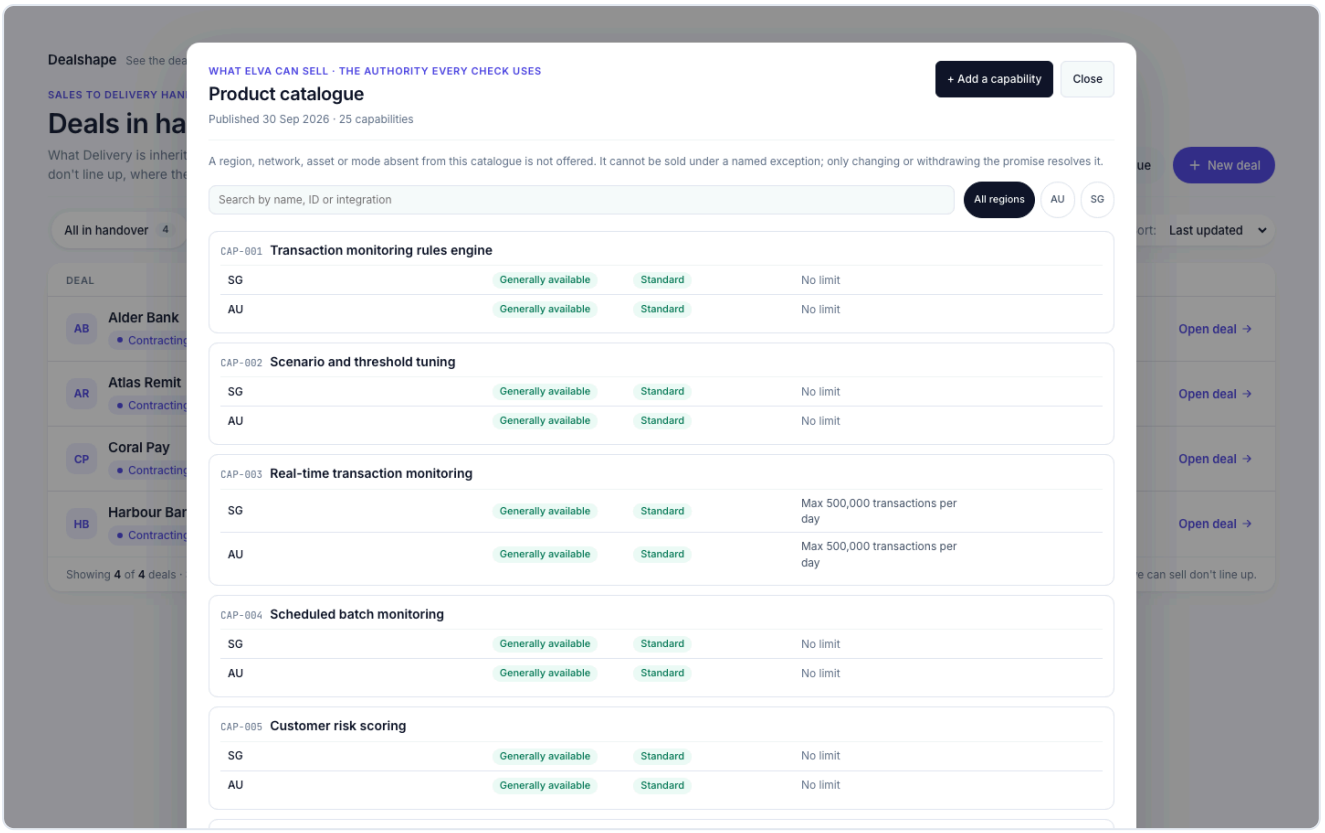
8 · What changed, after a named exception was added. The approval gap closed, with the evidence quoted and the document named. The contract gap on the same commitment stays open: an approval doesn't put a promise into the contract.



9 · All three statuses. Needs attention (amber), Addressed by note (outlined grey, with who recorded it) and Closed by documents (solid green). The brief's re-confirmation warning appears because a new SOW version arrived. *For this screenshot, the SOW step was re-checked by code, with no model call, because the model reading wasn't cached for this exact sequence. The screen is the app's real rendering.*



10 · Locked handover record. Read-only. The verdict states honestly what Delivery inherits, and the only actions are "All deals" and "Print".



11 · Product catalogue (pop-up). What the vendor can sell, by region: status, how it can be sold, and limits. It is the authority every check uses.

Issues I've already spotted in these screens (go beyond these)

- **5:** the document shows raw Markdown symbols (#, **). It should render as formatted text.
- **8 and 9:** the sidebar shows a new version with the original document's date (for example "Draft SOW · v2, 9 Oct").
- **9:** a closed commitment has no line saying what closed it. The drawer shows it, but the row doesn't.
- **9 and 10:** the brief's re-confirmation warning is amber, which is the colour that otherwise means a commitment needs attention.
- **11:** the catalogue uses green chips ("Generally available", "Standard"). That breaks the rule that green means only Closed by documents.
- **1:** every demo deal is in Contracting, so the stage column says little.

7. Evidence so far

What	Result	Honest reading
Sealed deal 1 (Coral Pay), v1: rules decide	Rules found 1 of 3 planted issues; a single model call found 3 of 3	The rules didn't generalise beyond development wording, so detection was rebuilt
Sealed deal 2 (Atlas Remit), v2: model detects, code verifies	8 of 8 labelled issues, 0 false flags	One deal and 8 targets is a small sample. It matched a single prompt; it didn't beat it. Its advantage is that every finding can be checked, so it can drive recheck and closure
Alder Bank (the demo deal)	Not part of any sealed evaluation	A demonstration, not a measurement
Reviewers	Head of Growth (6 Oct), COO (15 Oct), Delivery lead (16 Oct), one outside UI review	All friendly contacts. **No unaided test yet:** I explained the app before each reviewer tried it
Automated tests	677 Python, 57 front-end, all passing	They cover behaviour, not usefulness

8. Weak points I already know

- **Sales prepares the handover,** so the people who made a promise are the ones asked to surface the gaps in it. That's an incentive problem.
- **No connectors.** Documents are uploaded. A Drive link field exists, but there's no CRM, Drive or DocuSign integration.
- **It checks wording, not legal meaning.** "No matching wording found" means exactly that.
- **Synthetic, single-vendor world.** Every deal is in financial-crime software, and all were written for this build.
- **The product catalogue must be complete** for "not offered" to be meaningful. Real companies rarely keep one.
- **Paraphrase.** Reworded promises are where detection is weakest.
- **Could a strong single prompt do most of this?** My answer: the value is in the checking, the recheck and the locked record, not in the detection. Push on that.

9. Ask 1: stress-test the concept

1. Is "the Sales-to-Delivery handover" a painful enough moment to buy a tool for? Or is it a feature of something people already own (CLM, CPQ, the CRM, a PSA, Gong-style call tools)? Who does it best today, and how?
2. Who is the buyer, and who is the user? Is "visibility only, no workflow" a strength or a reason it stays a nice-to-have?
3. What would make a Delivery lead open this on day one of every deal?

4. Where is the trust model (verified facts vs AI text, notes vs proof) over-engineered for the user? Where is it essential?
5. What would a sceptical COO or CRO say in the first minute of the demo, and how should I answer?

10. Ask 2: alternative demo scenarios

Why: Alder Bank is credible for financial-services buyers, but it needs domain knowledge (coaching scams, instant payments). I want options that land with a general business audience in 10 seconds.

Criteria for a good scenario:

- understood without industry knowledge;
- shows all four gap types, using exactly three commitments:
  - not approved internally;
  - not in the contract;
  - the contract says something different;
  - not offered at all;
- one gap closes with a document, one is addressed by a note, and one stays open at handover;
- a realistic paper trail of 8 documents across the stages;
- commercially current in 2026.

Starter ideas. Judge these and add better ones:

Scenario	Example mismatches
AI customer-support assistant for an online retailer	"Resolves 70% of tickets in month one" (not approved); "12 languages" (the contract says 4); "Shopify and Zendesk at launch" (Zendesk in beta)
Global payroll rollout for a 14-country employer	14 countries promised, 9 offered; EU data residency promised, missing from the SOW; dedicated payroll manager, never approved
Managed security (MDR) service	"15-minute response, 24/7" (the SOW says business hours); a named analyst (not approved); OT network coverage (not offered)
Fleet telematics for a logistics company	2,000 trucks by Q2 (the contract says 1,000); offline maps (not offered); custom SAP integration (missing from the SOW)
Implementation services for a CRM migration	"Full data migration included" (the SOW excludes attachments); training for 300 users (the contract says 50); go-live in 8 weeks (no approval)

For your top two, please give:

- the three commitments;
- a one-line paper trail per stage;
- which gap closes, which is noted, and which stays open;
- why it lands in 10 seconds.

11. Ask 3: enhancements

- **Per screen** (use the screenshot numbers): what to remove, simplify or make clearer, and what would make it feel like a premium, modern 2026 product.
- Rank every suggestion as **impact** (high / medium / low) against **effort** (small / medium / large).
- **Flag any suggestion that breaks a rule in section 4,** and say why you'd break it anyway, if you would.
- **One "wow" moment** for the demo that stays honest. Nothing staged, and nothing the data can't back.

12. Out of scope (please don't suggest)

- Workflow: tasks, approvals, assignees, deadlines, notifications.
- Risk scores, or AI-suggested business impact.
- Anything that lets a person set the stage or close a gap by clicking.
- Real company or customer data.